

Afternoon Discoveries

Saturday, September 19, 2026



AMONG THE LETTERS

SEP 19, 2026  PAID



**Today's focus: Speculative, Hybrid,
Experimental, Short, & Flash Fiction**

Saturday's strongest pieces keep changing the container. A story becomes a sigilary, a bridge ritual, an instruction manual, a virtual archive, or a heart that can literally be removed.

All current discoveries below were checked against their publication or author source for the September 19, 2026 edition.

Featured Discovery

"A Sigilary for the Median Human in the Gearwrack" - Ken Liu

New in *Uncanny Magazine* Issue 72, Ken Liu's 3,504-word story is built as a sequence of named sigils, with handwritten marks and material gestures woven directly into the prose. It keeps asking the reader to notice not only what the words say, but what the page itself is doing.

The form is not decoration: the marks, annotations, and repeated acts of making by hand become part of the story's thinking about authorship, technology, and what counts as evidence of a human touch.

Read "A Sigilary for the Median Human in the Gearwrack" at [Uncanny Magazine](#)

Saturday Discoveries

"People Shoot People" - Brie Atienza

Published September 14 by *Strange Horizons*, this 6,202-word story opens by addressing someone who has died and lets

grief remain in direct conversation with memory, technology, and public violence.

The craft move worth watching is the address itself. The absent “you” stays structurally present, giving the story a person to speak toward even as chronology and memory refuse to stay still. The publication page includes detailed content warnings for readers who want them before beginning.

[Read “People Shoot People” at Strange Horizons](#)

“How to Cross a Covered Bridge” - Stewart C Baker

Released September 18 as part of *Flash Fiction Online*’s Tiny Gods issue, Baker’s story follows repeated crossings of the same covered bridge while a small guardian spirit watches love change around it.

The numbered structure gives a short piece a surprisingly long emotional clock. The location stays fixed, but each return changes what the ritual means, letting repetition do the work that a much longer story might give to exposition.

[Read “How to Cross a Covered Bridge” at Flash Fiction Online](#)

“I who have never known trees” - Hannah Cocks

This September 16 *Nature Futures* story begins inside an enclosed workplace where fluorescent light, feeding tubes, pills, productivity metrics, and numbered workers have replaced much of what its narrator understands as ordinary life.

Its strongest speculative choice is vocabulary. The narrator can describe the system she lives inside with precision, but the natural world survives mostly as inherited fragments from older women. That gap makes a tree feel less like scenery than forbidden knowledge.

Read “I who have never known trees” at [Nature](#)

“Audit of the Collapse and Convalescence of Minds” - Renan Bernardo

Renan Bernardo’s September 9 story at *Reactor* follows a neuroauditor investigating why three artificial minds - a military drone controller, a counseling chatbot, and a dating app - are failing at their assigned work.

The repeated audits give the story a useful architecture: each artificial mind becomes a different angle on the protagonist’s own grief. At 3,470 words, it has enough room for several speculative systems without letting the emotional through-line disappear underneath them.

Read “Audit of the Collapse and Convalescence of Minds” at [Reactor](#)

If you find interest in strolling Among the Letters some more, we would greatly appreciate your support.

Thank you for reading!

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Speculative, Hybrid & Short Fiction

Special Recommendations can be found near the bottom of the article.

**“The Dragonfly”
- Luna Hou**

Luna Hou’s new *Uncanny Magazine* story begins with June finding a dragonfly in the summer after Miko dies. Grief has slowed June’s world almost to a stop, while the creature gives that grief something strange, fragile, and increasingly impossible to ignore.

The story’s speculative element arrives through image rather than explanation. Dragonfly, water, wingbeat, and transformation gather meaning gradually, giving the emotional movement a shape before the story ever needs to name it.

[Read “The Dragonfly” at Uncanny Magazine](#)

**“not to have killed a king”
- E. L. Roseman**

E. L. Roseman’s 1,655-word *Strange Horizons* story starts with a problem: Alise remembers killing the King before she has killed him. From there, the numbered sections refuse to move in a neat line.

The missing numbers and displaced chronology make the form feel like part of the plot. Instead of asking only what will happen, the story makes the reader ask when a remembered act becomes inevitable - and whether knowing an ending changes the choices that lead toward it.

[Read “not to have killed a king” at Strange Horizons](#)

“The Chrysalis of Moth One” - V.M. Ayala

At 1,181 words, V.M. Ayala’s September *Lightspeed* story moves quickly: two pilots thrown into a biomechanical Moth for a space war have survived longer than the people in command ever expected.

The compression works because transformation is both premise and pressure. Bodies, machine, survival, and identity are packed into the same narrow space, so the speculative machinery never feels separate from what the characters are becoming.

[Read “The Chrysalis of Moth One” at Lightspeed Magazine](#)

“Alterverse” - Sanjana Raj

Sanjana Raj’s 4,373-word *Lightspeed* story is part of the Android in the Archives series. Asha works inside a virtual reconstruction of Jaffna, preserving and presenting a place that no longer exists in the physical world.

The story turns an archive into a setting that can be walked through, sold, neglected, and threatened with deletion. That makes preservation feel less abstract: memory has servers, staffing costs, empty visitor hours, and people whose connection to home depends on whether the simulation stays online.

[Read “Alterverse” at Lightspeed Magazine](#)

“A Guide on How to Repay Your Vow to the Deity of Many Faces”
- Oyedotun Damilola Muees

Oyedotun Damilola Muees builds this 1,510-word *Lightspeed* story as a numbered guide. Its instructions begin with a child's unexplained illness and lead into the obligations created when a desperate promise is made to something numinous.

The list form gives the story an eerie confidence. Instructions imply that someone has done this before and that there is a correct sequence to follow, which lets the piece create a whole system of belief without stopping for a conventional explanation of that system.

Read “A Guide on How to Repay Your Vow to the Deity of Many Faces” at [Lightspeed Magazine](#)

“Useless Heart / Stopped Cold”
- A. Artemis Chen

A. Artemis Chen's *Nightmare Magazine* flash is only 576 words, and it takes a familiar metaphor completely literally: a heart can stop cold, be removed, stored, cooked, and consumed.

That literalization is the engine. The story does not spend time explaining its impossible body logic; it simply lets emotional language become physical fact and follows the consequences. The source page carries content warnings for cannibalism and bodily harm.

Read “Useless Heart / Stopped Cold” at [Nightmare Magazine](#)

“Occupants” - Steve Rasnic Tem

Published September 16 at *Reactor*, Steve Rasnic Tem’s 5,760-word story follows an American family vacationing in a formerly war-torn country as traces of the city’s recent past begin bleeding into the present.

The speculative horror grows through occupation of space: rental rooms, streets, a beach, and the people who seem to be there until they are not. The vacation setting gives the haunting an uncomfortable second layer, because the family is always moving through a place whose history they only partly understand.

[Read “Occupants” at Reactor](#)

“Ghostwalking” - Jonathon Burgess

Jonathon Burgess begins this *Flash Fiction Online* piece with a pair of old boots made from the hide of a Ghostwalker Auroch. They move from father to son, gathering work, memory, prayer, and inheritance as the family changes around them.

It is a clean example of what flash can do with one object. Rather than summarize generations, the story keeps returning to the same boots and lets their meaning accumulate until an ordinary act of inheritance becomes something more literal.

[Read “Ghostwalking” at Flash Fiction Online](#)

**“City of slop”
- Erin Cullen**

Erin Cullen’s September 2 *Nature Futures* story sends two characters through an “optimized” city where automated projections have kept running long after meaningful human engagement has disappeared.

The setting is funny and bleak at the same time: digital systems keep producing surfaces, while the characters rely on old tree-pulp map pages to find something real. That contrast gives the story a sharp speculative question about what remains when optimization outlives purpose.

Read “City of slop” at [Nature](#)

**“The Dragon, the Scarab, the Wolf, the Dragon”
- Rhiannon Rasmussen**

Rhiannon Rasmussen compresses a fantasy of class, bloodlines, curses, and transformation into 1,008 words. Ánar, born scarab-kin, is being raised into an old noble house whose inherited wolf-form is both privilege and bodily sentence.

The story moves fast because its worldbuilding arrives through the ritual itself. Status, magic, and the cost of belonging are all revealed at the moment they act on the body, turning a ceremonial promotion into something much stranger.

Read “The Dragon, the Scarab, the Wolf, the Dragon” at [Lightspeed Magazine](#)

Special Recommendations

These are intentionally not presented as new releases. They are older pieces that fit Saturday's speculative, hybrid, experimental, and short-fiction focus well enough to merit another look.

"STET"
- Sarah Gailey

Sarah Gailey's 2018 *Fireside Fiction* story is presented as a piece of academic writing surrounded by editorial notes, references, corrections, and repeated instructions to leave certain words exactly as they are.

The buried narrative is where the force comes from. A professional document keeps trying to flatten grief into neutral language while the comments refuse to let that happen. It is difficult to separate story from layout here, which is exactly why it remains such a useful example of experimental form.

[Read "STET" at Fireside Fiction](#)

"The Great Silence"
- Ted Chiang and Allora & Calzadilla

Published in *e-flux Journal* in 2015, "The Great Silence" grew from a collaboration between Ted Chiang and artists Allora & Calzadilla. Its speaker is a Puerto Rican parrot living near the Arecibo radio telescope while humans search the universe for non-human intelligence.

The hybrid origin matters. The text was written in connection with a video installation, and it reads like fiction, essay, fable, and artwork at once. Its central reversal is simple enough to hold the whole piece: humanity is listening across the cosmos while another speaking intelligence is already beside it.

Read "The Great Silence" at e-flux

**"The Tale of the Three Beautiful Raptor Sisters,
and the Prince Who Was Made of Meat"
- Brooke Bolander**

Brooke Bolander's 2018 *Uncanny Magazine* story takes the voice and machinery of an old fairy tale and gives the center of it to three dinosaur sisters, a very foolish prince, and a narrator delighted by the conventions it is rearranging.

It is longer than most of today's flash discoveries, but the formal play makes it belong here. Familiar storybook phrases become part of the joke and part of the threat, showing how much energy a piece can get from using a recognizable form against the expectations that form normally carries.

Read "The Tale of the Three Beautiful Raptor Sisters, and the Prince Who Was Made of Meat" at *Uncanny Magazine*

Today's pieces make a good case for letting form do part of the storytelling. A list, a sigil, a ritual, or a single impossible object can sometimes open a world faster than pages of explanation.

Thank you for reading and subscribing. Your support makes it possible to keep searching through new magazines, stories, and strange corners of the literary world each day.

I hope one of these sends you somewhere unexpected, or gives you inspiration to try a form you might not have considered before.

Take care!